



# Freed by the Cap, Refilled by the Cohort

## Auditing a Residence-Hall Laundry-Booking Cap's Wait-Time Effect Against This Year's Larger Move-In

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### Background

Every residence-hall laundry room already reports live machine availability. When this year's larger move-in cohort met the same machine count, halls capped bookings per resident instead of buying a machine. Does the cap shorten the wait, or just relocate it?

### Aims

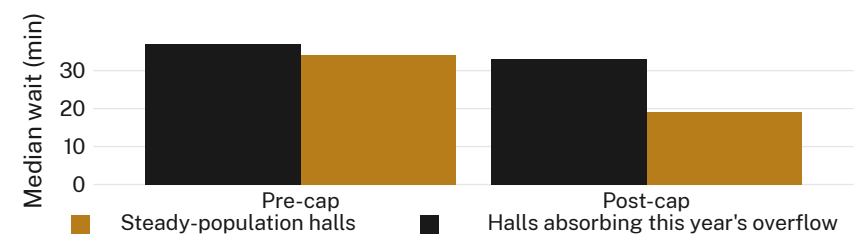
- Compare median wait-to-next-slot before and after the cap's introduction
- Test whether the effect holds once this year's larger move-in cohort is accounted for
- Check whether the cap changed who books, not just how often

### Methods

- 4 halls · booking-app timestamp log · 10-week term (Weeks 1–5 pre-cap, 6–10 post-cap)
- Wait = minutes between opening the app and the next available slot starting
- Cap start date fixed across halls; 2 absorbed a delayed dorm closure's overflow (+27% residents), 2 held steady

### Results

Steady-population halls' median wait fell 44% after the cap (34 to 19 minutes). Halls absorbing this year's overflow fell 11% (37 to 33 minutes) over the same term.



Median wait for a free washer, Weeks 1–5 vs 6–10 of Term 2, 2026: steady-population halls (n = 2) drop from 34 to 19 minutes; overflow halls (n = 2) drop from 37 to 33 minutes.

### Discussion & conclusions

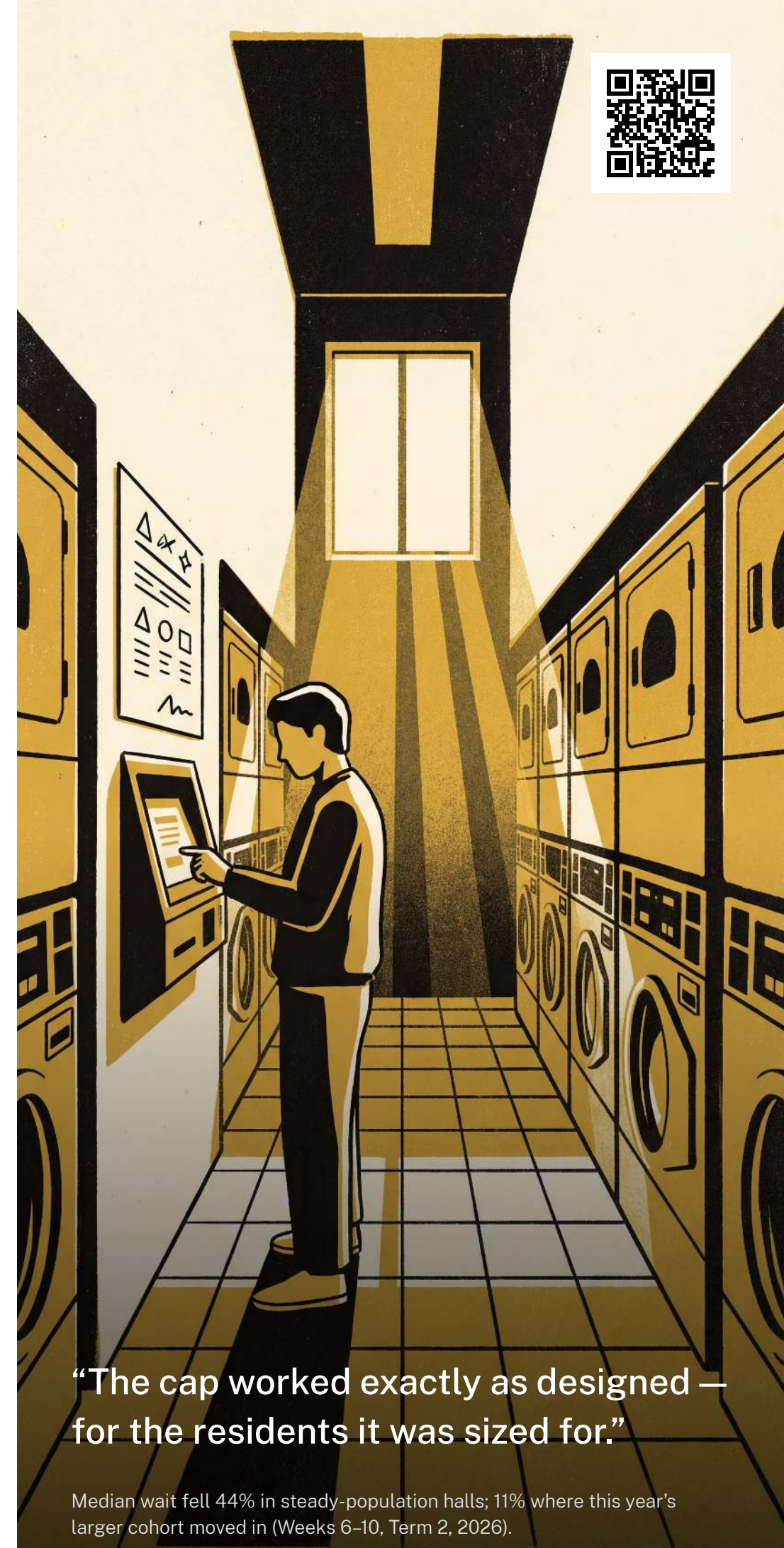
The cap's per-booking effect is consistent across both hall groups; only the pooled average diverges. This year's larger cohort refills a freed slot about as fast as the cap frees it, and the residence-hall office reports the pooled figure as the cap's headline result. Next: publish the wait metric split by cohort growth, not pooled.

### References

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Booking-app event log only; no resident identifiers retained. Cap policy set independently of this study.

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“The cap worked exactly as designed — for the residents it was sized for.”

Median wait fell 44% in steady-population halls; 11% where this year's larger cohort moved in (Weeks 6–10, Term 2, 2026).